P 04-19

ACCREDITATION OF LABORATORIES, PROFICIENCY TESTING SCHEME PROVIDERS AND REFERENCE MATERIAL PRODUCERS

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1. Purpose and Scope

The purpose of this document is to define the process for accreditation of Testing, Calibration, Medical, and Blood Transfusion Service Laboratories, Proficiency Testing Scheme Providers and Reference Material Producers, herein referred to as conformity assessment bodies (CABs). This document outlines how SANAS plans and conducts assessments of these CABs to the SANAS accreditation requirements, the requirements of the applicable standards/guides, as well as the International Laboratory Accreditation Co-operation (ILAC) and the African Accreditation Cooperation (AFRAC) requirements.

2. Definitions and References

SANAS PM01	SANAS Policy Manual
SANAS A 01	References, Acronyms and Definitions
SANAS F 147	Terms and Conditions of Accreditation
SANAS P 06	Preparation of Reports
SANAS P 12	Handling of Complaints and Appeals
SANAS P 20	The Responsibilities and Duties of the Approval Committees and Accreditation Managers in the Approval and Decision on Accreditation
SANAS P 35	Remote Assessments – Management and Execution
SANAS P 41	Sampling for Assessment Purposes
SANAS R 03	Nominated Representative and Signatories: Responsibilities, Qualifications and Approval
SANAS R 04	Conditions for use of Accreditation Symbols, Reference to Accreditation and Combined Marks
SANAS R 48	Proficiency testing and other comparison programme requirements for Calibration Laboratories
SANAS R 51	Suspensions, Withdrawals and Re-instatement of Accredited / GLP Compliant Organisations
SANAS R 72	Requirements for relocation of SANAS accredited medical Laboratories
SANAS R 76	Extraordinary (unscheduled) assessments to SANAS accredited facilities
SANAS R 80	Proficiency testing and other comparison programme requirements for Testing and Medical Laboratories
ISO/IEC 17025	General requirements for the competence of testing and calibration laboratories
ISO 15189	Medical laboratories - Particular requirements for quality and competence
ISO/IEC 17043	Conformity Assessment – General Requirements for Proficiency Testing
ISO 17034	General requirements for the competence for reference material producers

3. General

3.1 The function of SANAS is to assess and recognise the competence of CABs to competently perform specified conformity assessment activities and subsequently to ensure, by monitoring, that the applicable accreditation scheme requirements are maintained.

3.2 The SANAS Policy Manual (PM) and all other SANAS documents applicable to the CAB is available on the SANAS website www.sanas.co.za. It is the responsibility of the CAB to ensure that they are familiar with the relevant SANAS documents.

3.3 An authorised representative of an applicant CAB provides information to SANAS on its signatories / staff in the relevant standard specific application, and submits it to SANAS together with the pre-requisite documentation as required in the application form.

3.4 The table below describes areas of accreditation and the applicable accreditation standards:

Areas of Accreditation	Accreditation Standard/ Scheme
Testing Laboratories	ISO/IEC 17025, and where applicable WADA ISL

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Calibration Laboratories	ISO/IEC 17025
Medical Laboratories	ISO 15189, and where applicable WADA ISL
Blood Transfusion Laboratories	ISO/IEC 17025 or ISO 15189 (H/O) and Standard of Practice for Blood Transfusion
Proficiency Testing (PT) Providers	ISO/IEC 17043
Reference Material Producers	ISO 17034

3.5 Assessment of the competence of CABs is carried out using various assessment techniques, which includes, but are not limited to:

Assessment techniques	**Purpose**	**When is this done**
Document reviews	To evaluate whether the CABs' system conforms to the relevant standard(s) and other SANAS accreditation requirements.	On receipt of an initial application for accreditation
On-site visits to the CABs and other sites where the CAB performs calibrations or tests, operates proficiency testing schemes from or produces reference materials	To determine, through the gathering of objective evidence, whether the CAB is competent and conforms to the relevant standard(s) and accreditation requirements, and where applicable regulatory and legal requirements.	Refer to Annexure 2 & 3
Witnessing or Vertical Assessment	To determine whether: - Documented procedures are being followed; - Staff have the skills required to perform scope of accredited work or for which accreditation is sought; - The training and supervision provided is effective; - The resources available are adequate; - Any defects in the equipment have been detected and addressed; and - answers to questions asked can be supported.	As part of on-site assessment process
Review of performance of proficiency testing or other interlaboratory comparisons or Measurement Audits	To confirm that the CAB monitors the validity and reliability of test / calibration results / reports through the review of results, detection of trends and implementation of appropriate corrective actions.	1) Prior to an on-site initial assessment and re-assessment 2) As a sampling exercise during the on-site assessment
Interviewing.	**CAB personnel:** To confirm that personnel are knowledgeable and competent in the performance of their duties.	As part of on-site assessment process
	Technical Signatories (TS) or applicant TS: To confirm the competence and suitability of the TS, and that the TS: • understands significant issues in the calibration/ test, etc. processes; • is able to critically evaluate results; • takes responsibility for the adequacy of results; • understands the requirements for accreditation and the scope of accreditation held/sought; and • understands SANAS, accreditation and standard requirements (Refer to F147 - *Terms and Conditions of Accreditation* and R03 - *Nominated Representative*	As part of on-site assessment process: - for applicant TS - as sampling of TS

	and Signatories: Responsibilities, Qualifications and Approval for additional information)	
	Nominated Representative (NR): To confirm that the NR: • is familiar with and fully understands the requirements of the relevant standard or principles applicable to the CAB's scope of accreditation; • Irrespective of other duties and responsibilities, has a defined responsibility and the authority to ensure that the management system is implemented and followed at all times to support their proposed/current accreditation scope; • has direct access to the highest level of management at which decisions regarding policy or resources are made; • has an in-depth knowledge of all SANAS accreditation requirements applicable to the scope of accreditation; particularly as defined in the SANAS Terms and Conditions of Accreditation (F147), the SANAS R (requirement) and TR (technical requirement) documents; and • keeps SANAS informed of changes as required by the SANAS R03 "Nominated Representative and Signatories: Responsibilities, Qualifications and Approval".	1) As part of on-site assessment process 2) Can be a telephonic interview at any time during the Accreditation process on application of a new NR
Desktop Reviews	• At the discretion of the AM, where an extension of an existing scope is applied for, however it does not change the technique, principle or technical signatory.	At any time during the accreditation cycle
Unannounced visits	• To follow up on the investigation and resolution of a complaint against a CAB; • To follow up on significant changes in relation to a CAB which may have an effect on the CAB's accreditation / compliance status; or • For any other reason that SANAS may deem necessary to confirm on-going compliance to accreditation requirements.	Refer to SANAS R76 "Extraordinary (unscheduled assessments to SANAS accredited facilities"
Remote Assessments	• An assessment carried out using electronic means. The use of remote assessment is evaluated on a case-to-case basis for effectiveness. • The structure of a remote assessment is similar to that of an on-site assessment.	In cases where it may not be possible or feasible to conduct on-site assessments Refer to SANAS P 35 "Remote Assessments – Management and Execution

3.6 The purpose of the assessment is to determine whether a CAB complies with the applicable standard, the SANAS accreditation requirements / criteria, and any mandatory International Laboratory Accreditation Co-operation (ILAC) or African Accreditation Cooperation (AFRAC) requirements.

3.7 SANAS uses Technical Assessors (TAs) and/or Experts (TEs) with the relevant specialist knowledge to assess the competence of the CAB to perform the activities in the scope for which accreditation is sought. The assessment teams are required by SANAS to maintain confidentiality, and to sign a confidentiality form specifying the need to declare any conflict of interest or potential conflict of interest. Their activities will be confined to assessing the CAB's

activities for compliance with the requirements and reporting their findings to the CAB and to SANAS.

3.8 Refer to Annexure 1: The Accreditation Process
3.9 Refer to Annexure 2 and 3: The Assessment Cycle.

4. Application and Resource Review

4.1 On receipt of a completed application and the documentation as required in the specific application form, the Accreditation Manager (AM) or his/her delegated Assessment Specialist shall:

i) Review the application for completeness and verify that the required information and documentation has been submitted;
ii) Review the acceptability of technical information provided, such as, but not limited to:
- Validation information;
- Proficiency Testing performance (Refer to Note below);
- Uncertainty budgets; or
- Any other technical aspects or procedures.

iii) Determine the suitability of the application and verify whether SANAS is able to carry out the assessment in the scope applied for, in terms of its competence and the availability of personnel suitable for the assessment activities and decision-making;
iv) Verify whether SANAS will be able to carry out the initial assessment within 1 year of receipt of the application, and where this will not be possible, the reasons shall be communicated to the applicant;
v) Verify that the application Declaration form has been signed by the authorised representative, thereby binding the applicant to the Terms and Conditions of Accreditation (F147); and
vi) Seek agreement from the applicant to the appointment of a specified Team Leader and the technical assessors /experts required to cover the scope of the application.

Note: All applicant laboratories are required to participate in appropriate proficiency testing or Interlaboratory comparisons for the scope of accreditation required and provide SANAS with the relevant proof on application of participation and satisfactory performance.
Refer to SANAS R48 “Proficiency testing and other comparison programme requirements for Calibration Laboratories” or SANAS R80 “Proficiency testing and other comparison programme requirements for Testing and Medical Laboratories”

4.2 At any point in the application or initial assessment process, if there is evidence of fraudulent behaviour, if the CAB intentionally provides false information or if the CAB conceals information, SANAS will reject the application or terminate the assessment process.

4.3 During the review of the suitability of the application information, the Accreditation Manager may seek advice from a technical assessor / expert regarding the acceptability of the technical information provided, should this be required. In this case, the technical assessor / expert will be required to provide a response to the Accreditation Manager in writing.

4.4 Prior to any work being carried out, SANAS will provide a quotation detailing the cost of the application, the document review and initial assessment. Acceptance and payment of the invoice will be required to proceed to the next stage of the assessment process. A quotation may be sent to the applicant in stages.

4.5 An application that has not proceeded to the initial assessment stage within 1 year from the date of application will lapse and the CAB informed. Unless otherwise agreed with SANAS, this may result in the CAB having to re-apply for accreditation. All application fees will be applied for the re-application.

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5. Document Review

5.1 The purpose of the document review is to evaluate whether the CAB's Management System complies with the relevant standard(s) as well as other SANAS accreditation requirements.

5.2 Document reviews are conducted on initial application for accreditation.

5.3 The process to be followed for a document review is as follows:

5.3.1 The CAB conducts a review of their documentation and completes the Management and Technical requirement checklists for the relevant accreditation standard, detailing where in their documents the accreditation requirements are addressed.

Comments on HOW the requirements of the standard have been implemented, Clause no's, sub-clause no's, procedure numbers MUST be captured.

5.3.2 The CAB submits the completed application form, checklists, management system manual and where required, procedures to SANAS.

5.3.3 SANAS records the date of receipt and forwards the information submitted to the appointed Team Leader.

5.3.4 The Team Leader will send the relevant technical information to the technical assessor / expert for their feedback on the acceptability of the information provided. The technical assessor / expert will be required to provide a response to the Team Leader in writing. The relevant Team Assistant must be copied on the correspondence.

5.3.5 The Assessment Team confirms from the information submitted by the CAB whether the requirements of the relevant standard, regulatory requirements and any other requirements for accreditation are addressed in the management system manual.

5.3.6 The Team Leader shall compile and submit to the SANAS AM a document review report within 4 weeks of receiving the information. The report shall contain comments on any deficiencies / omissions and a recommendation on the way forward. Where the recommendation is not to proceed with further assessment, this shall be clearly justified. The report may be accompanied by the appropriate SANAS checklists completed by the CAB and the Team Leader. The AM shall review the report prior to sending it to the CAB.

5.3.7 Within 4 weeks of receipt of the completed application and documentation, and the application fee, the document review report must be submitted to the CAB.

5.3.8 A maximum period of 6 months is allowed for applicant CAB to address any document review findings.

6. Pre-assessment

6.1 Although not mandatory, a pre-assessment can be carried out at the request of and in agreement with the CAB to:

i) discuss any findings related to the documentation;
ii) seek further information on the management system;
iii) briefly examine the systems which have been established and implemented;
iv) discuss any arrangements which have been made to include multiple locations, subcontracted activities, etc. within the management system;
v) agree on the proposed scope of accreditation; and
vi) finalise the expertise required for the assessment team.

Note: Due care shall be exercised to avoid consultancy during the pre-assessment.

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6.2 The CAB will be quoted on the request of a pre-assessment visit.

6.3 The pre-assessment visit will normally be completed by the Team Leader within one day. The Team Leader will supply the CAB with at least a recommendation report (F04) and if applicable, completed non-conformance forms (F03).

6.4 The CAB may need to make changes to its policies, procedures and practices prior to SANAS undertaking the initial assessment. The CAB is responsible to inform SANAS when they have addressed the findings and are ready for the initial assessment.

7. Initial Assessment

7.1 Preparation for Assessment

7.1.1 During the application, the CAB will provide SANAS with all the information required to plan the assessment. SANAS may request additional information as needed.

7.1.2 SANAS shall ensure that the appointed assessment team as a whole has the appropriate knowledge of the specific scope of accreditation and the understanding to make a reliable assessment of the competence of the CAB to operate within the scope of accreditation sought.

7.1.3 The CAB will be sent notification of the date(s) of the assessment and the names of the proposed assessment team members, including the organisations they work for, for acceptance.

7.1.4 A CAB may object to the appointment of assessors. Objections however will only be considered if the CAB has provided clear and valid reasons, in writing and within 7 days of the notification, and proving that a conflict of interest exists. The Accreditation Manager will decide whether a change of assessor is warranted or not.

7.1.5 If the CAB has good reason to object to an assessor / assessment team, and no other local assessor is available, SANAS may opt to use qualified assessors from other accreditation bodies that are signatories to the AFRAC or ILAC Mutual Recognition Agreement (MRA). These assessors shall be classified as technical experts, therefore shall be accompanied by a SANAS qualified assessor. The CAB will be liable for the full costs covering assessor fees, travel, subsistence and accommodation of the international assessor and monitor.

7.1.6 The time required for the initial assessment is normally 2 days, but will be left to the Accreditation Manager's discretion depending on the complexity of the organisation, the geographical spread of its activities, the proposed scope of accreditation, the structure of the supporting management system and where relevant, the combination of multi-standards for accreditation.

7.1.7 The nature of the initial assessment will depend on the scope of accreditation required by the CAB and the complexity of the supporting management system that is being operated. The following elements however will be covered:

i) assessment of the central office and, where applicable, sample collection sites;
ii) assessment of multiple locations (Satellites/branches/temporary sites) where applicable; and
vii) assessment of on-site activities where applicable.

7.1.8 Refer to SANAS P41 "Sampling for Assessment Purposes", which defines SANAS' procedure and specific requirements for sampling of locations, personnel and the scope of accreditation within the accreditation cycle to determine the competence of the CAB to perform the activities covered by the scope of accreditation.

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7.1.9 At least 2 weeks prior to the assessment, the Team Leader shall develop and send to the CAB an assessment plan indicating the date(s) of the assessment, the assessment team members, the activities to be assessed, the locations at which activities will be assessed, and the personnel to be assessed where applicable.

7.1.10 Should the CAB not be able to accommodate any of the planned activities, this should be communicated to the Team Leader as soon as possible, in order for the assessment plan to be adjusted, as far as possible and within the constraints of the P41 “Sampling for Assessment Purposes”.

7.1.11 Prior to the assessment, the assessment team members will each be provided with an assessment pack containing the relevant assessment documentation, including the checklists completed by the CAB and the document review report.

7.2 On-site Assessment

7.2.1 The SANAS assessment team will start the assessment with an opening meeting with the CAB at which the purpose of the assessment and accreditation requirements are clearly defined, and the assessment plan as well as the scope for the assessment are confirmed. (Refer to F01 “Opening Meeting”)

7.2.2 The SANAS assessment team shall conduct the assessment based on the assessment plan, and shall analyse all relevant information and objective evidence gathered prior to and during the assessment to determine the competence of the CAB as determined through its conformity with the requirements for accreditation.

7.2.3 Various assessment techniques will be used to establish whether:

i) the management system supports competence against their Scope of Accreditation, is appropriate to the CAB’s needs, organisational arrangements and methods of operation, including multiple location operations and number of staff members;

ii) the CAB conforms with all of the requirements for accreditation;

iii) the CAB has implemented all the requirements of the management system effectively to ensure valid results / data are generated each and every day;

iv) the operational, administrative and technical procedures used to support the management system manual are complete, technically valid and appropriate.

7.2.4 The initial assessment is done so as to establish full confidence in the competence of the CAB. Where it is the initial assessment of a satellite CAB, the implementation of the management system within the satellite, the knowledge of the CAB personnel of the management system and the interface / communication between the satellite CAB and central office is crucial. Implementation within the satellite CAB of the above will be assessed.

7.2.5 The following on-site assessment techniques will be used to establish whether the management system complies with the accreditation requirements, and is fully implemented:

i) Questioning / interviewing of management and personnel who have an involvement in or bearing upon the quality of all aspects of activities covered by the scope of accreditation;

ii) Examination of records, files, documented information and certificates / reports issued by the CAB;

iii) Witnessing of technical personnel performing conformity assessment activities. Personnel should be witnessed at a suitable site where the conformity assessment activity is performed;

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iv) SANAS form F15 “Witnessing of Activity” shall be completed for each witnessing assessment and where applicable for calibration laboratories, form F17 “On-site evaluation of a Calibration Laboratory”. If a suitable site is not available, a simulation may be considered.

7.2.6 SANAS' assessors’ role during witnessing of work in the scope of application is one of observer. They will not adversely affect or influence the work being performed. The team will be looking to see that as a minimum:

i) the CAB personnel member has the competence for the activity performed;

ii) the CAB personnel member’s competence is consistent with the records;

iii) the CAB personnel member has access to all necessary documented methods and procedures;

iv) the procedures are up-to-date;

v) the CAB personnel member implements the procedures in full and correctly, i.e. no short cuts, no personalised application where it is not permissible to do so;

vi) records of all observations are made while on site as required by the procedure;

vii) records clearly identify the activity performed, the method/procedure used, and when it was done;

viii) all records and raw data are signed/initialled, stamped and traceable as applicable;

ix) reports/ certificates issued comply with the CAB’s, SANAS’, and relevant standard requirements;

(x) facilities and equipment are fit for accreditation purposes.

7.2.7 If a CAB cannot provide at least one witnessing and/or sufficient supporting evidence in order for a vertical assessment to be conducted on the day of the assessment, the Assessor has the right to terminate the assessment, and re-schedule for another day at full cost to the CAB. It is permissible for a CAB to simulate an activity, or portion of an activity for this purpose.

7.2.8 The assessors shall review performance of proficiency testing and any other interlaboratory comparisons.

7.2.9 The Assessors will record all information gathered during the assessment on the relevant SANAS assessment forms provided for this purpose. The assessor records shall be sufficiently comprehensive as to allow the Approval Committee (AC), to support the recommendation made by the assessment team.

7.2.10 The Assessors will record all information gathered whilst witnessing the performance of an activity and viewing records in the CAB. This information will be used to make a decision on the competence of the CAB. Where necessary, additional supporting documentation can be attached as evidence of non-compliance or otherwise.

7.2.11 Each Assessor will record his/her own non-conformances during the assessment as they encounter them by fully completing a separate F03 (Non-conformance, Corrective Action and Clearance Report) for each non-conformance raised. The Assessor will obtain the signature of the CAB representative on each F03 completed. Each F03 shall refer to a specific clause of the relevant Guide/Standard or any of the other SANAS accreditation documents.

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7.2.12 The Calibration Accreditation Manager may at his or her discretion include artefacts, measuring devices or instruments to be used during the witnessing of a calibration during the assessment. The measurement results obtained during this witnessing may not be used as a measure of the competence of the calibration activity.

7.3 Assessor Meeting

7.3.1 After the members of the assessment team have completed their individual assignments in accordance with the assessment plan, the assessment team will hold a private pre-close out meeting at which each team member summarises their conclusions and contributes to a co-ordinated view of the status of the applicant CAB.

7.3.2 The assessors will reach agreement on whether non-conformances are classified as major or minor non-conformances based on their severity and their influence on the accuracy of results. Where the assessment team cannot reach a conclusion on a non-conformance, the team shall refer to the relevant Accreditation Manager for clarification.

7.3.3 The Team Leader will summarise the conclusions of the assessment team with regard to the competency and conformity of the CAB on the F04 “Recommendation Report” form.

7.3.4 The Team Leader will report any matters for the attention of the Accreditation Manager or the relevant STC on the Assessment Matrix, or by email to the Accreditation Manager.

7.3.5 The Team Leader shall complete the relevant assessment matrix form, which shall be accumulative for the whole cycle, to track the coverage of scope at each assessment within a cycle, and track areas of concern for follow-up at the next assessment.

7.4 The Closing Meeting and Summary of Findings

7.4.1 At the end of the assessment, a closing meeting shall be held between the assessment team and the CAB, where a summary of the assessment team’s findings and recommendation will be presented. The guidelines as indicated in the closing meeting agenda (F 01) will be followed.

7.4.2 The Team Leader will provide the CAB with an opportunity to seek clarification on the findings including any non-conformances, and their basis.

7.5 The Report and Recommendation (Refer to P06 “Preparation of Reports”).

7.5.1 A Recommendation Report (F 04) and any non-conformance reports (F 03) will be provided to the CAB at the closing meeting. The CAB may request copies of additional assessment documentation completed by the assessment team.

7.5.2 Where non-conformances have been identified, the CAB shall provide, within 3 months of the **initial** assessment:

i) An analysis of the extent and cause (root cause analysis) of the non-conformance; and
ii) Sufficient evidence that the corrective action has been implemented. (the AM will allow a total of 6 months for clearance).

7.5.3 In most cases evidence of corrective action can be provided to SANAS by email/courier at their cost.

7.5.4 The corrective actions provided to SANAS by the CAB will be reviewed by the relevant assessor, to determine whether the actions are appropriate and sufficiently

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addresses the non-conformance. Once satisfied, the assessor will clear the non-conformance.

7.5.5 Where the CAB's root cause analysis and/or corrective actions are found not to be sufficient, further information will be requested from the CAB, or a follow-up assessment may be carried out to verify effective implementation of corrective actions at the cost of the CAB.

7.5.6 On clearance of all actions, including those arising from visits to multiple locations and on-site activities, the assessment documentation will be submitted to the Approval Committee, who will review the information submitted and make a decision. (Refer to P20 “The Responsibilities and Duties of the Approval Committees and Accreditation Managers in the Approval and Decision on Accreditation”).

7.5.7 On approval of accreditation, and once any outstanding fees have been paid, the CAB will be granted accreditation and a Certificate and Scope of Accreditation will be issued to the CAB. (Refer to P10 “Accreditation Certificate”).

8. The Accreditation Cycle

8.1 The Accreditation Cycle begins on or after the day of the decision to grant the initial accreditation or decision after re-assessment, and is valid for a period as stipulated below, subject to the Accreditation Requirements being met (Refer to F147 “Terms and Conditions of Accreditation”):

Areas of Accreditation	***Accreditation Cycle***
Testing and Calibration Laboratories	5 years
Medical Laboratories	4 years
Blood Transfusion Laboratories	4 years
Proficiency Testing (PT) Providers	4 years
Reference Material Producers	5 years

8.2 Once accreditation has been granted, the AM shall apply an assessment programme in which the assessments of the CAB’s activities throughout the cycle are planned, and conducted in accordance with SANAS P41 “Sampling for Assessment Purposes”. The Assessment programme shall ensure that the requirements of the international standards and other normative documents containing requirements for CABs and the scope of accreditation are assessed taking risk into consideration.

8.3 Refer to Appendix 2 & 3 for guidance on assessment planning throughout the cycle.

8.4 When establishing the assessment programme, the AM shall consider factors such as information about the CAB’s management system and activities, its performance, risks identified, etc. This information will normally be recorded by the Team Leader on the Assessment Matrix and/or by email to the relevant Accreditation Manager, or will be contained in the Approval Committee decisions.

8.5 The Assessment Programme consists of:

8.5.1 Six-month follow-up assessments;
8.5.2 Surveillance assessments; and
8.5.3 A re-assessment prior to expiry of the Certificate of Accreditation.

9. Six Month Follow-up Visits

9.1 A follow-up visit to the main office is planned for approximately 6 months, but not exceeding 12 months after accreditation has been granted. On recommendation by the Team Leader

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and approval by the Accreditation Manager, a branch / satellite CAB may also be included in the 6-month follow-up visit.

9.2 The 6 month follow-up is normally conducted by the Team Leader only. The purpose of the visit is to follow-up on any non-conformances raised at the initial assessment and to ensure that the management system is still implemented and functioning properly.

9.3 Where the non-conformances raised at the initial assessment are of a technical nature that warrants an on-site verification, part or all of the technical assessors may be included in the 6-month follow-up visit, the costs of which are for the CAB's account.

9.4 6-month follow-up assessments will normally be limited to:

- Verification of the satisfactory clearance of any non-conformances raised at the initial assessment;
- A general overview of the continued implementation of management system by the Team Leader (TL);
- Where relevant, a general overview of any technical area as decided by the AM and TL;
- Where relevant, an in-depth assessment of any specific area of the management and/or technical system as decided on by the AM and TL, due to any previous non-conformance resulting in the questionable continued competence of either a specific area, or of the CAB as a whole.

9.5 The 6-month follow-up does not normally include a witnessing or vertical assessment, unless this is required by the AM and TL. The management and where relevant, technical checklists or other assessment forms may be completed to show proof of what was checked at the assessment.

10. Surveillance Assessments

10.1 Following accreditation, SANAS will check for continued compliance with accreditation requirements by planning and carrying out regular surveillance visits at periods not exceeding 24 months.

Note 1: Refer to Appendixes 2 and 3 for guidelines on the planning of the assessment cycle.
Note 2: SANAS may decide to assess a CAB at shorter intervals, based on evidence of poor conformance to accreditation requirements throughout the cycle.

10.2 A representative sample of the scope of accreditation is assessed at each surveillance assessment (Refer to SANAS P41 "Sampling for Assessment Purposes").

10.3 At least three weeks prior to the assessment, the laboratory shall submit to SANAS the following reports and/or documentations, in order for the assessment team to prepare for the assessment:

- The latest Internal Audit Report/s (typically not older than 12 months)
- A copy of the Management Review minutes or report, (typically not older than 12 months)
- Management and Technical checklists fully completed by the CAB, e.g., F48 and F49 (in word format)
- A comprehensively completed F176 Proficiency Testing requirements checklist (in word format)
- A copy of the laboratory's PT Participation Plan (5-year plan)
- Latest PT/ILC results;
- Calibration program/plan;
- Risk register;
- Organogram
- Validation reports for the sampled methods (technical assessors to advise)

Note 1: The above shall apply to both the surveillance and re-assessments.

Note 2: Additional documents or reports may be requested at the discretion of the AM and/or assessment team.

10.4 Accredited CABs shall notify SANAS of any significant revisions to their management system or any other changes that can affect their technical competency (such as loss of or new technical signatories, change of methods, etc.), which will be reviewed during these surveillance visits. Where SANAS was notified in sufficient time (6 weeks prior to the assessment), verification of changes will be done as part of the next scheduled assessment, or where not possible, through an additional assessment. No scope changes will be accepted after the assessment. The need for an additional assessment will be determined by the period within which the change needs to be effected. CABs shall be responsible for any additional costs incurred for additional assessments. (Refer to Clause 11)

10.5 Where non-conformances have been raised, the CAB will be given a maximum of 25 working days to submit an analysis of the root cause analysis of the non-conformance; and evidence that the appropriate action has been taken and the corrective action effectively implemented.

10.6 The assessment team may however recommend that an "On-site Clearance of Findings Visit" is required to allow the assessor(s) to clear the non-conformances on-site. (Refer to clause 12.1)

10.7 Should an accredited CAB fail to correct any non-conformances raised within 51 days, the Accreditation Manager shall implement procedures in accordance with R51 "Suspensions, Withdrawals and Re-instatement of Accredited / GLP Compliant Organisations".

11. Reassessment

11.1 At least 6 months before the end of the accreditation cycle, the CAB is required to submit an application for renewal of accreditation to SANAS with at least the following information:

- The fully completed Management & Technical checklists containing comments on how the requirements of the relevant standard are implemented and in which policy / procedure it is addressed;
- SANAS may request any other information as needed (e.g. validation or PT for new scopes added).

11.2 On receipt of the application and supporting documentation, a re-assessment shall be planned and performed at least 3 months prior to the expiry of the Certificate and Scope of Accreditation. Information gathered from assessments performed over the accreditation cycle shall be taken into consideration when planning the re-assessment. This information is normally obtained from the assessment matrix form completed for the cycle.

Note: Should the application for renewal of accreditation not be submitted before the expiry of the Certificate, a re-assessment may not be conducted prior to the end of the accreditation cycle, resulting in the expiry of the CAB's accreditation and the CAB having to re-apply for accreditation as a new applicant. All application fees and timeframes will be applied for the re-application.

11.3 The application information will be submitted to the Assessment Team once they are appointed, in order to allow the team to prepare for the assessment and request any further information / clarifications before the assessment. Feedback on information need not be provided, unless there are concerns about the information provided, and where the CAB is required to take action.

11.4 The reassessment shall confirm the competence of the CAB and cover all the requirements of the standard(s) for which the CAB is accredited. (Refer to Annexure 2: "Assessment Cycle").

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12. Additional Assessments

Where an additional or unscheduled assessment (such as COF visits, re-instatement visits, extension of scope or approval of Technical Signatories) coincides with a re-assessment, the "additional visit" will be included in the assessment plan of the re-assessment and may result in additional days for the assessment as well as additional assessment personnel. The fees will be adjusted to include any additional assessor units, assessment days, travel, accommodation, subsistence, etc.

12.1 Clearance of Findings (COF) Visits

12.1.1 The purpose of an on-site clearance of findings is to verify implementation and effectiveness of corrective actions taken by the CAB. The on-site clearance of findings should be conducted within **3 months** of the assessment at which the COF visit was recommended, except in the case of initial assessments and re-assessments. All evidence and supporting documentation must first be submitted to SANAS for perusal and acceptance prior to the on-site COF visit.

1.1.2 The assessment team shall only clear the non-conformance(s) if the evidence supports that proper root cause analysis was undertaken, the corrective action had been effectively implemented.

12.1.3 In the case where additional non-conformances that are not related to the original non-conformances were raised during the COF visit, and that will impact negatively on the accreditation status of the CAB, the AM, in consultation with the Executive: Accreditation, where required, will decide on the way forward, and whether to:

a) Request the CAB to submit corrective actions before the pack is submitted to the AC (where the NC(s) are serious enough to impact the credibility of results produced by the CAB);

b) Submit the pack to the AC in the meantime, but still require the CAB to submit corrective action/supporting evidence within a stipulated timeframe. In this case the corrective action will be checked by either the assessor or AM for clearance, the pack will not need to be re-submitted to the AC (Where the NC(s) are not considered serious enough to impact on the accreditation status, and the CAB is able to provide evidence of corrective action taken); or

c) In severe cases, such as issues that could result in suspension, arrange an additional assessment of the CAB, as per SANAS document R76 "Extraordinary (unscheduled) assessments to SANAS accredited facilities".

13. No work carried out by a CAB

13.1 If an accredited CAB cannot provide proof of work performed in a technical scope for two (2) consecutive assessments, and cannot provide evidence that competence is maintained in any particular scope, that scope is to be suspended and the SANAS R 51 process instituted.

13.2 If the CAB performs any work in the suspended scope during the suspension period, they must inform SANAS at their earliest opportunity for arrangements for a re-instatement assessment.

13.3 If the CAB does not perform any technical work in the suspended scope within the suspension period, the suspension process will be followed and reduction of scope will be recommended to the AM as required by SANAS R 51.

14. Scope of Accreditation

14.1 It is SANAS' policy to define the scope of an CAB's accreditation as precisely as possible. CABs will therefore be asked to specify in detail the information of conformity assessment activity for which accreditation is sought and the locations at which these activities are to be carried out. This scope will be agreed upon as far as possible before the assessment in order

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to determine the extent of the assessment activities. Following successful assessment, the scope, including standard specifications / methods / procedures relevant to the testing/calibration/proficiency testing/production of reference materials concerned will be identified on the accreditation schedule.

14.2 Following accreditation, the certificate and associated scope of accreditation is the property of SANAS, and shall be returned to SANAS on request.

15. Multi-Standard Assessment

The nature of their business may require the CAB to comply to more than one accreditation standard. This is becoming more prevalent in Inspection combined with Testing, Certification or both. As the cost, time and management of different accreditations for the same CAB can be onerous on SANAS and the CAB, the following shall apply:

15.1 Where possible and practicable, CABs who wish to be assessed to two (2) or more accreditation standards may be assessed to multiple standards at the same assessment, using one TL knowledgeable in the multi-standards for which accreditation is sought. However the technical expertise required shall match the scope for which accreditation is sought.

15.2 Where the scope applied for falls under different programmes (E.g. Inspection and Testing), the applications for the different programmes must be completed in full and submitted to SANAS. Only one copy of supporting documents such as the Management System Manual and relevant procedures will need to be submitted. However the required checklists for the different standards will be required.

15.3 The AM's responsible for the relevant programmes will process the application forms as described in section 4 of this document.

15.4 It is important for the CAB to ensure that the applicable standards are fully addressed in their documented system (Management System Manual). An integrated management system is preferred.

15.5 A pre-assessment is mandatory for a multi-standard assessment.

Note 1: Each Multi-Standard accreditation application will be processed by SANAS Management on its own merits, taking into account the AFRAC, ILAC and IAF MRA'/MLA's in place at the time of application.

16. Multi-site CABs

16.1 An applicant that operates from a central office through a number of locations may seek a single accreditation provided that the conditions specified in the relevant standard or guide are fulfilled. Groups of Medical Laboratories operating under the same management system are allocated individual accreditation numbers, and each satellite CAB shall be individually assessed.

16.2 CABs shall under no circumstances franchise their accreditation activities to other CABs or organisations.

16.3 SANAS will seek to establish through objective evidence and by using various assessment techniques that:

i) all locations are operating under the same management system;

ii) all locations are included in the internal audit programme and central review process.

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16.4 Temporary locations must be working to the same accreditation requirements and shall be subject to assessment as part of the accreditation process to provide evidence of the operation and effectiveness of the system.

16.5 During the main office assessment SANAS may need to see records of certain activities, which are being carried out at different locations.

16.6 If SANAS raises non-conformance(s) at the main CAB or at any one of the locations of a CAB with multiple locations, it is the Nominated Representative's responsibility to ensure that a proper root cause analysis is conducted, and that the corrective action process applies to all affected locations (Refer to R03 "Nominated Representative and Signatories; Responsibilities, Qualifications and Approval"). In the event that the results of any of the assessments reveal that there is a significant weakness or inconsistency in the application of the management system, SANAS will review the assessment program.

16.7 Failure by one location to comply with SANAS requirements and the requirements of the applicable standard may lead to suspension / withdrawal of that location. If the cause of non-conformance is the lack of central control then the corporate accreditation will be the subject of review by SANAS and may lead to suspension or withdrawal of accreditation of all locations.

16.8 SANAS must be advised of any changes to location addresses and activities. The establishment of any new locations from which the CAB proposes to offer an accredited service must be notified to SANAS before these can be included in the scope of accreditation. The need for assessment of the new location will be reviewed, the scope of accreditation will be amended as appropriate and the location will be included in the assessment plan.

16.9 The initial assessment is done so as to establish full confidence in the competence of the CAB. Where it is the initial assessment of a satellite CAB, the implementation of the management system within the satellite, the knowledge of the CAB staff of the management system and the interface / communication between the satellite and main office is crucial. Implementation within the satellite CAB of the above will be assessed.

17. Regional and International Locations

17.1 Locations, which are operated outside South Africa, will be subject to the same accreditation requirements as those located in South Africa.

17.2 Where assessments are to be covered in a language other than English, arrangements must be made by the CAB for an independent interpreter to be available if required. SANAS will conduct and report assessments in English.

17.3 SANAS shall ensure that the assessors have the required knowledge and skills in the geographic areas, by providing him/her with the specific legislative, regulatory and cultural provisions in the economy for the conformity assessment activity being assessed, in order for the assessor to familiarize him/herself with.

18. Extension of scope of accreditation

18.1 There are 2 types of extensions to the scope of accreditation:

i) A whole new scope including the conformity assessment activities within that scope;
ii) Conformity assessment activities added to an existing accredited scope.

18.2 Following receipt of an application for extension of the scope of accreditation, including supporting information to show that the requirements for accreditation are met, SANAS will review the application in accordance with Clause 4, and determine whether or not there is a need for an additional assessment or if an assessment of the requested scope can occur during the CABs next planned assessment.

18.3 The following factors will be taken into consideration:

i) existing scope of accreditation;
ii) risk associated with the activities or locations to be covered in the scope extension;
iii) location at which the extension of scope is sought;
iv) whether or not a different set of competencies is required to perform the requested scope;
v) competency of staff.

18.4 For an assessment of the extension of scope applied for to take place at the next scheduled assessment, the application must be submitted to SANAS at least 6 weeks prior to the next assessment date.

18.5 The assessment programme and planning for the subsequent assessments will be reviewed and the CABs annual fees may be revised accordingly.

19. Timescale for the Accreditation Process

SANAS makes every effort to ensure that all applications are processed as efficiently as possible. The time taken to process an application depends on a number of factors some of which are outside the control of SANAS. The timing is dependent on:

i) Payment of application and assessment fees;

ii) The quality of the applicant's documentation and the extent to which it complies with SANAS accreditation requirements. A delay can occur due to insufficient documented procedures and submission of inadequate Management System Manuals and /or completed checklists;

ii) The availability of suitable assessors;

iii) The level of implementation of the system and availability of evidence of the technical competence;

iv) How efficiently the applicant CAB clears the non-conformances after the initial assessment; and/or

v) The availability of the resources within SANAS.

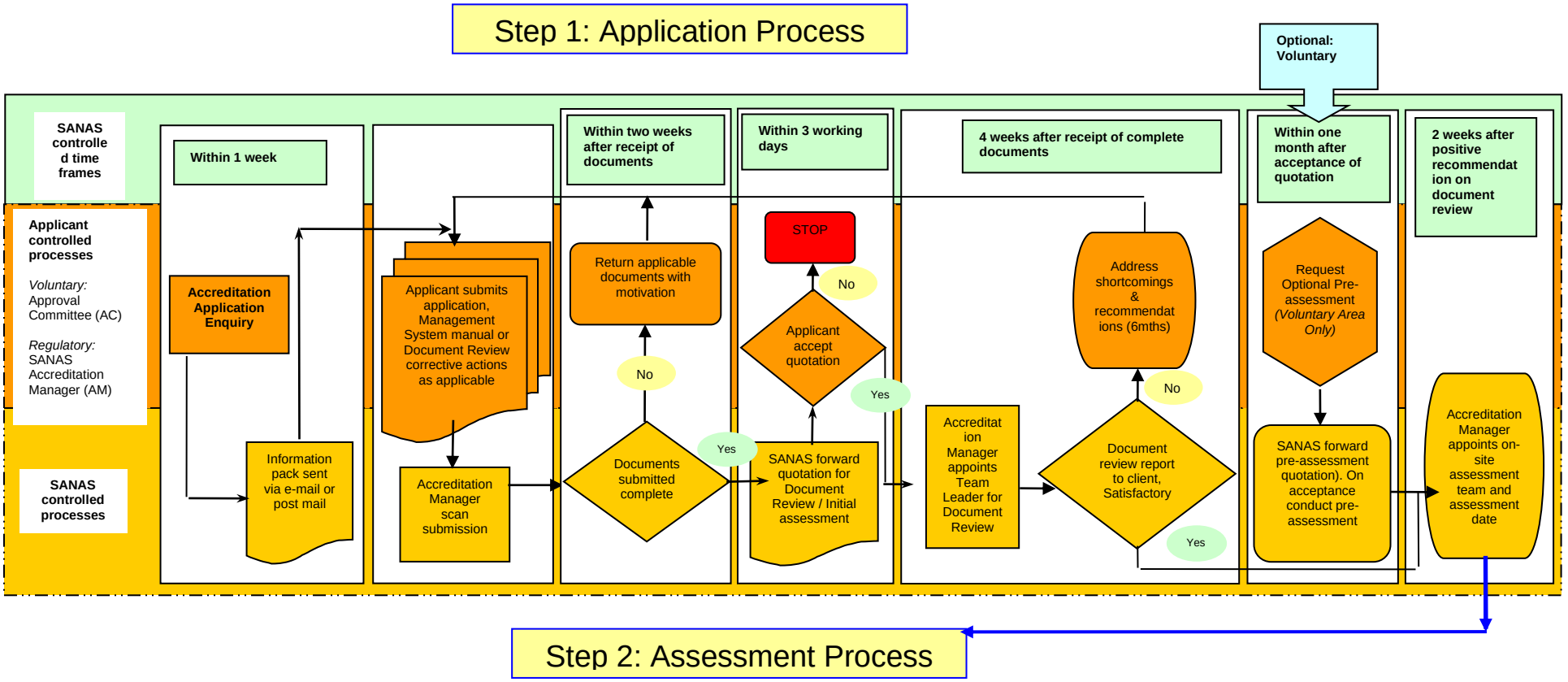
20. CABs Providing Accreditation Services

Accredited CABs shall not provide certification / accreditation services to any standard used as a basis for accrediting CABs (e.g. ISO/IEC 17025 or ISO 15189), as this behaviour of the accredited CAB will place SANAS, against its will, in the unacceptable situation of having to provide the same service that an accredited CAB performs.

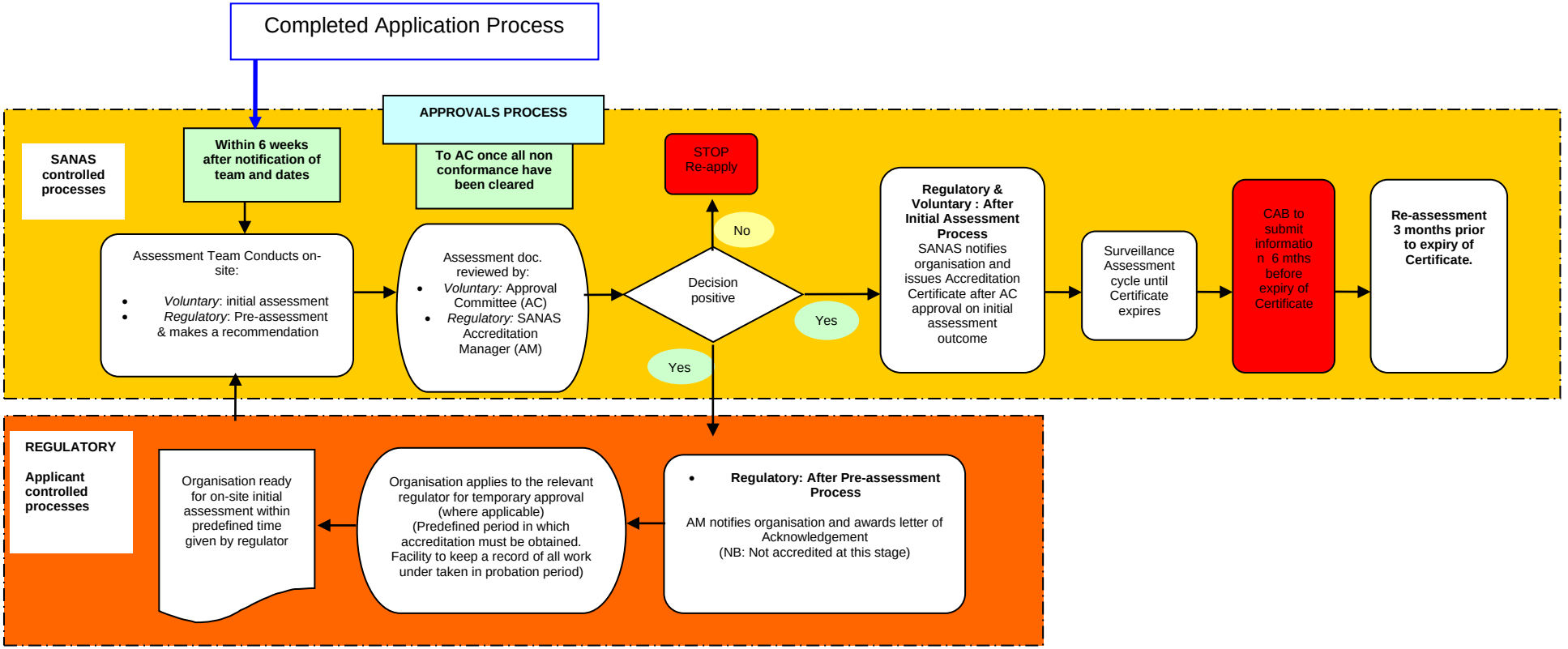
Note: It is accepted that an accredited CAB may have to evaluate subcontractors to confirm that they meet the CABs' requirements, which may include accreditation standards such as e.g. ISO/IEC 17025. Documentation issued to subcontractors as a result of a successful assessment should clearly state that this is only for the purposes of the subcontract and is not certification or accreditation.

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ANNEXURE 1: The Accreditation Process



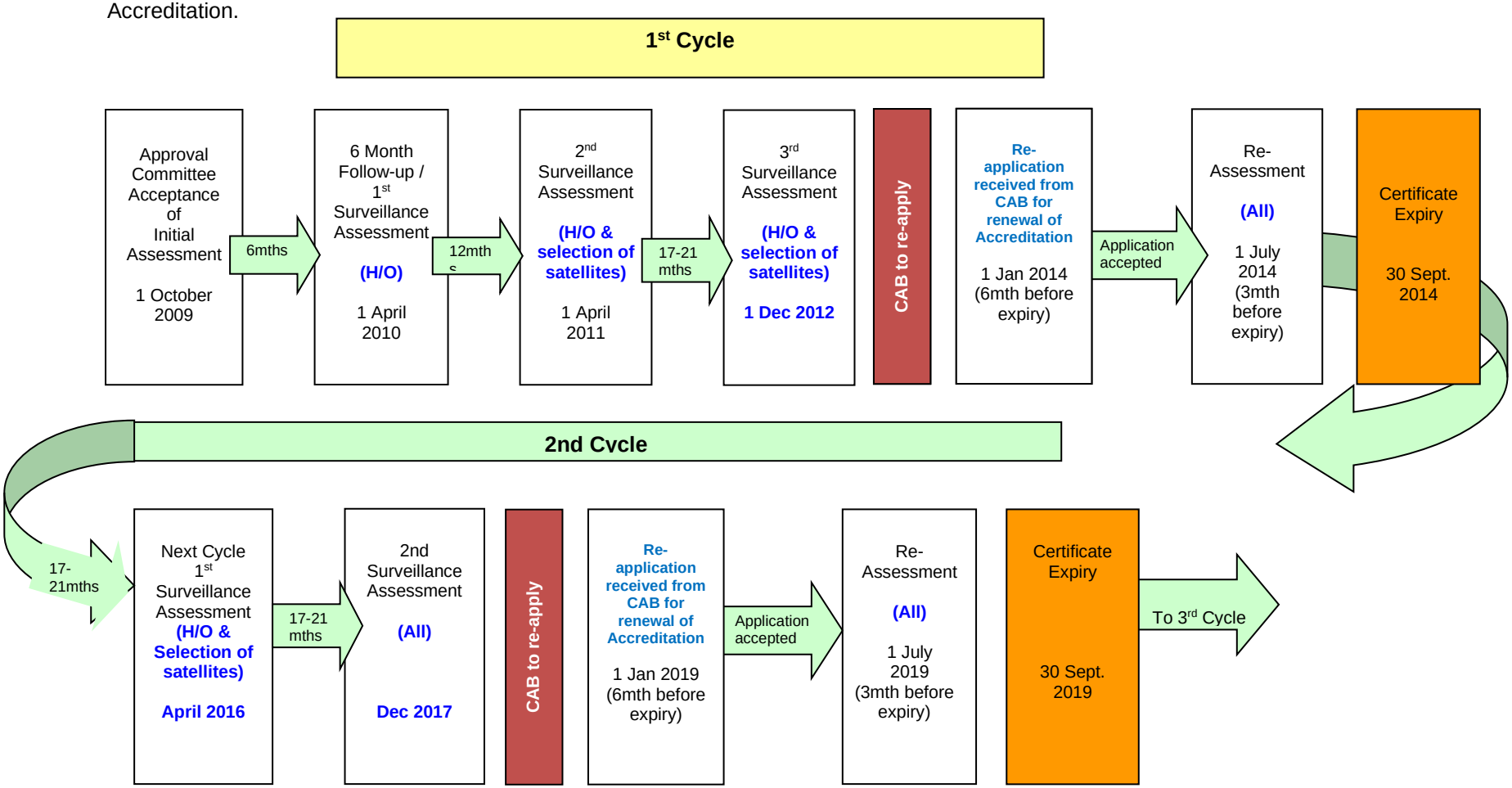
Step 2: Assessment Process



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ANNEXURE 2: TESTING AND CALIBRATION LABORATORIES, REFERENCE MATERIAL PRODUCERS - The 5 Year Assessment Cycle.

The flowchart below provides a basic guideline on the normal 5 year accreditation cycle. The Accreditation Manager will plan the cycle of each CAB to ensure that all the required assessments are conducted within the cycle, and before the expiry date of the Certificate and Scope of Accreditation.

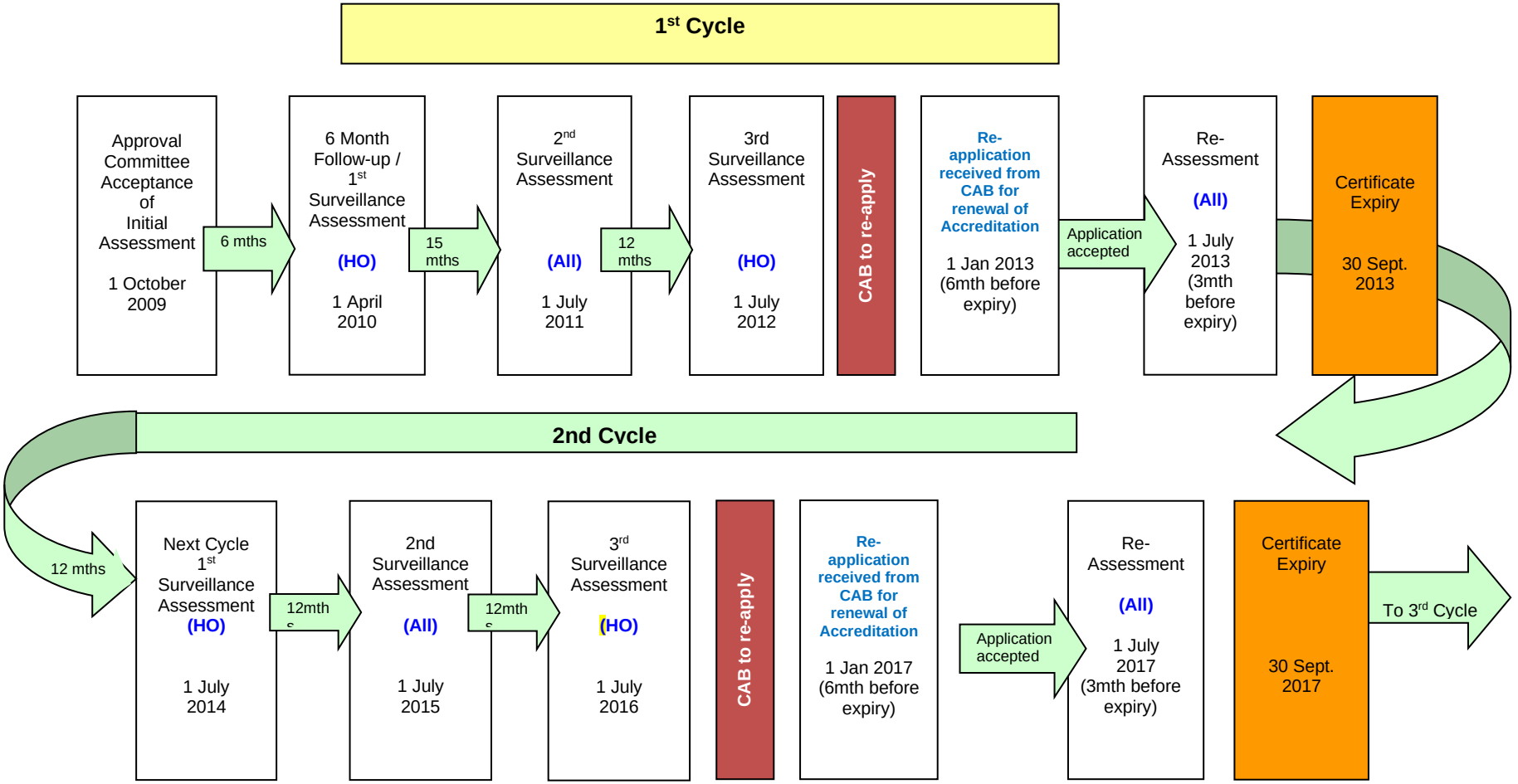


NOTE: <u>Surveillance dates are approximate, but may not exceed 24 months. However, the re-assessment dates are fixed and may not be changed.</u>
Laboratories may be assessed at shorter intervals depending on the recommendation of the assessment team, and shall be liable for additional costs associated with the increased frequency of assessing.

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ANNEXURE 3: MEDICAL LABORATORIES, PT PROVIDERS & BLOOD TRANSFUSION LABORATORIES - The 4 Year Assessment Cycle

The flowchart below provides a guideline on the normal 4 year accreditation cycle. The Accreditation Manager will plan the cycle of each CAB to ensure that all the required assessments are conducted within the cycle, and at least 3 months before the expiry date of the Certificate and Scope of



NOTE: <u>Surveillance dates are approximate, but may not exceed 24 months. However, the re-assessment dates are fixed and may not be changed.</u>
Laboratories may be assessed at shorter intervals depending on the recommendation of the assessment team, and shall be liable for additional costs associated with the increased frequency of assessing.

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APPENDIX A: Amendment Record

Proposed by	Section	Change
AM	All	All reference to “Certified Reference Materials” changed to “Reference Material Producers”
AM	10.3	New clause added